

Learning Memo Week 5 · Data Analysis in a Grounded Theory Study

Gerlach & Cenfetelli (2020), Constant Checking Is Not Addiction, MIS Quarterly 44(4), 1705-1732

Yasir A. Malik

Florida International University · College of Business

Doctor of Business Administration · Cohort 8.14

GEB 7911 · Qualitative Research Methods in Business · Instructor: Dr. Cristina Gonzalez

September 18, 2026

Gerlach and Cenfetelli set out to explain constant checking of digital devices without importing the label the literature had already attached to it. Their method section is unusually explicit about procedure, which makes it a useful case for examining the five data analysis activities in Creswell and Poth's spiral. Page references below are to the published article.

1. Managing and Organizing the Data

The authors collected data from 90 Internet users using two techniques deliberately chosen against each other: 46 in-depth semi-structured interviews and 44 anonymous online surveys with open-ended questions (p. 1709). The stated reason for the pairing is that surveys “should allow responses that may not be comfortably made in person.”

The sequence is itself an organizing decision rather than a scheduling one. They began with 21 interviews, paused to run surveys among 20 European and 24 United States participants, compared the two bodies of data, and only then returned to conduct 25 further interviews (p. 1709). Organization here is not filing; it is a structure built so that one slice of data can be held against another.

The corpus is quantified precisely: over 35 hours of conversation and approximately 680 single-spaced pages of transcript at 12 point, plus roughly 85 pages of survey text (p. 1709). All interviews were recorded and transcribed, most conducted face to face with 11 by telephone (p. 1709 n.3). Coding was carried out in Atlas.ti (p. 1710). Appendix A preserves the question set and notes that questions were “added, modified, or removed” as the study progressed, so the instrument's own history is part of the organized record.

2. Reading and Memoing Emerging Ideas

Reading is described at a specific grain. Open coding proceeded by “analyzing our material line-by-line, providing descriptive and often preliminary conceptual labels to meaningful units of text at the phrase or word level” (p. 1710). That is reading as an analytic act rather than familiarisation before the real work begins.

Memoing is named directly: the authors “engaged in memo-writing—a sense-making technique, which helps to reflect on ideas and understand the data” (p. 1710). The clearest visible trace of it is the evolving interview protocol. As constant checking emerged as a major theme, new questions were introduced, including what are examples where you constantly check digital channels, when and where do you do it and how often, and why is that important to you (p. 1709). Questions that specific do not come from a protocol written in advance; they come from reflection on data already gathered.

3. Describing and Classifying Codes into Themes

The authors follow Glaser (1978) rather than Strauss and Corbin or Charmaz. Classic grounded theory commits them to emergence and to not forcing data into prior categories, which is precisely the charge they later bring against the addiction literature.

Classification runs in three named passes (p. 1710). Open coding produced preliminary conceptual labels line by line. Selective coding then narrowed the work: IT-mediated state-tracking “emerged as an interesting construct and earned its way to the center stage of our study,” after which coding focused on that construct and the categories significantly associated with it. Theoretical coding followed, in which the authors “theorized about relationships between the emergent categories and validated these relationships against our data.”

Constant comparison is the engine underneath all three. They compared “data from different individuals using different ITs in different situations that led to different outcomes,” and also compared emerging findings against literature that became relevant (p. 1710). Participants were deliberately recruited across age, gender, country and occupation, from consultants and engineers to bartenders and homemakers, specifically “to compare whether and how the phenomenon differed between them” (p. 1709). Sampling was configured to make comparison possible.

The output of this activity is Table 1, a data structure diagram running from first-order codes through second-order categories to themes (p. 1711).

4. Developing and Assessing Interpretations

Development is governed by theoretical sampling: “intermediate results of data analysis guided us in terms of what additional data were needed and where to sample from next,” continuing until theoretical saturation, when “no new insights resulted from additional data” (p. 1709). Interpretation and collection are described as “inextricably linked” rather than sequential.

Assessment is the more interesting half, and the design contains two deliberate attempts at disconfirmation. First, the surveys were run specifically “to see if anonymous respondents would offer different insights”; the authors report that survey data were consistent with interview data, which they read as evidence of no interview bias. Second, 24 respondents were recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk “to see whether a non-convenience sample would generate different insights,” and constant comparison showed it did not (p. 1709). Both checks were built into the sampling rather than applied afterward.

Preconceptions are handled explicitly. Existing theories “are not used as a lens to interpret the data but to relate the emergent theory to the prior literature,” and literature “did not serve as a priori theory but was treated as data” (pp. 1709-1710).

The title's negative claim is the clearest instance of interpretation being assessed rather than merely developed. The authors did not test participants against addiction criteria. They built a neutral construct from the data and then argued that state-tracking habits “might look like addictions on the surface, as they are often performed with high frequency, are difficult to control, and can cause problems. Yet, they are very different behaviors.” Their methodological charge against the prior literature is that it applied the construct of addiction “in a confirmatory manner.”

5. Representing and Visualizing the Data

Three representations do distinct work. Table 1, the data structure diagram, lays first-order codes, second-order categories and themes side by side (p. 1711), which lets a reader trace any theme back to the codes that produced it rather than accepting the theme on the authors' word. Figure 1 presents the theory as a whole, titled A Theory of IT-Mediated State-Tracking (Overview) (p. 1720), converting the categories into a process with directional relationships.

Appendix B then supplies additional quotes organised by the themes in Table 1. The authors attach a caveat to it: the table “presents snippets of participants' statements outside of the statements' context,” and information not shown may have informed the coding. Flagging the limit of one's own evidence display is itself an analytic act, and a more candid one than most appendices manage.

6. My Takeaway About Qualitative Data Analysis

What stays with me is the paper's central methodological charge, that technology-addiction research applied its construct “in a confirmatory manner.” The problem was not bad coding. It was that the category arrived before the data and the analysis then found it. Reading five discrete analysis activities laid out against that charge made clear that the activities exist largely to make that failure harder to commit: line-by-line coding before selective coding, comparison across deliberately varied slices, and sampling designed so that a disconfirming case could appear.

This bears directly on my own proposal, which asks what happens to professional judgment when an AI system produces an analytical conclusion that matches one the auditor has already formed. That is the same structure as the confirmatory-manner problem, relocated from a research literature to an audit workpaper. It is also why the analysis plan I have written bars AI from assigning a code, naming a theme, or writing an interpretation, while permitting it to transcribe, organise and challenge. If I let a model propose my themes and then agreed with them, I would reproduce the phenomenon inside the analysis of the phenomenon.

Second, the paper undermines the passive voice that qualitative writing often relies on. Themes do not emerge on their own. Somebody codes line by line, somebody decides a construct has earned its way to the centre, somebody stops collecting. Gerlach and Cenfetelli make each of those decisions visible and attributable, and the article is more credible for it.

Third, and least comfortable, is the gap between claiming an activity and evidencing it. Memo-writing is asserted once and never shown. The two disconfirmation checks both report finding nothing, with no stated threshold for what a difference would have been. These are not fatal criticisms of a strong paper, but they are a reminder that a method section can satisfy every item on a checklist and still leave a reader unable to verify its most important claims. That is a standard I would rather be held to in advance than discover at a defence. This study is grounded theory and my proposal is phenomenological, so the spirals differ in their particulars; the five activities do not.

Reference

Gerlach, J. P., & Cenfetelli, R. T. (2020). Constant checking is not addiction: A grounded theory of IT-mediated state-tracking. *MIS Quarterly*, 44(4), 1705-1732.

Disclosure of Artificial Intelligence Use

Generative artificial intelligence (Claude, Anthropic) was used to organise this memo, to format it, and to check the prose for clarity and grammar. The selection of evidence from the article, the evaluation of each analysis activity, the critical observations, and the takeaway are my own. No confidential, identifiable, or restricted data was provided to any artificial intelligence system. This disclosure is made in accordance with the FIU University Graduate School policy on artificial intelligence use and the course syllabus.